

from 10 inches to 12.1 inches with a wide aspect ratio, and processing comes from the power-optimised Intel Centrino platform and AMD's Turion platform as well.

This category consisted of 10 models from various vendors. Sony and Fujitsu each had one, and Acer, Compaq, MSI, ASUS, TCL, and ACi were the other contenders.

Features

Feel and build quality

Ultra-portables offer a fine balance between size, weight, performance, and battery life. The size and weight are primarily determined by the screen size. In this round-up, all the notebooks were equipped with 12.1 inch screens, except for the Sony VAIO TX37GP with its 11.1 inches—some resorting to widescreen, and others to a normal aspect ratio. The display quality offered was nearly the same on all these models—except for the Sony TX. Instead of relying on conventional CFL (Compact Fluorescent Lightbulbs) for the display's backlight, Sony has used bright LEDs. There are two advantages of using this: first, the screen was an amazing 0.5 cm thick, and second, they help conserve battery usage.

Fujitsu's Q2010 was another product that exuded quality. Despite being slightly larger than the Sony VAIO, it's light-weight, with superb build quality. The Fujitsu Q2010 is a conventional ultra-portable—that is, the optical drive is built into a dock that features additional ports. Fujitsu was generous enough to bundle along an extra battery that can be charged in the dock while the other battery powers the laptop.

The ASUS U5F was the lone contender from Taiwan: it has a personality of its own, and does not rely on the similar-looking SKUs (Semi-Knockdown Unit) coming out of Taiwan's factories. As with most products from ASUS, it has good build quality. However, the area surrounding the screen has scope for improvement—it's quite flimsy.

Compaq and Acer come next in build quality. Compaq offers a better look and feel, and Acer has their typical robust feel going for them. Zenith and Gigabyte had the typical silver-black combination—they can definitely do with face-lifts. The sparkling black body on the MSI gives it a distinct identity among its Taiwanese brethren.

The ACi Elite reminded us of the older Toshiba Protégés, with the distinct grille that hides the speakers. Build quality was sturdy and up to the mark. The TCL K22 looks a little too old for our liking.

Weight

Tipping the scales at 1.2 kg, Fujitsu's Q2010 (sans its battery dock) was the lightest. Sony's VAIO TX37GP is another feather-weight at 1.25 kg. MSI's and ACi's ultra-portables are at the other end of the scale at 2.1 and 1.8 kg respectively. The rest had their weight spread across the 1.4 - 1.8 kg spectrum.

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The ASUS U5F
Top-notch performance in
a pint-sized package

Ergonomics

Ergonomics is one parameter all ultra-portables have to compromise on. Despite its size, the Fujitsu Q2010 offers the best ergonomics of them all—a good keyboard and a nice touch pad. The Sony VAIO comes nipping at Fujitsu's feet; however, its keyboard is a little taut. The ASUS U5F and Compaq are neck-and-neck for third position—they have similar keyboards. The Acer 3012, MSI Megabook, and Zenith have reasonable keyboards, touchpads, and space for one's palm. The Gigabyte N211U has a mushy keyboard that could do with some improvement.

Specifications

On paper, the ASUS U5F certainly seems to be the killer ultra-portable.

With a 2 GHz Core Duo processor mated with 1.5 GB of memory on an

Intel 945GM chipset, the configuration is something one rarely sees even on much larger notebooks. The VAIO TX37GP, on the other hand, comes with a 1.2 GHz Core Solo processor with 512 MB memory—a trifle

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